Chapter 7. Game Concepts

Designing a video game begins with an idea. This chapter discusses how to turn that idea into a *game concept*, a more fleshed-out version of the idea that you can use as the basis for further discussion and development. Creating a game concept is what you do in the first stage of game design. Your goal at this point should be to write the high concept document that Chapter 2, "Designing and Developing Games," discussed. To do this, you don't have to have all the details worked out yet, but you do need to understand clearly what your game is about. You also need to know the answers to essential questions about your intended player, machine, and target audience, as well as how you plan to make money with your game (if you do). You learned how to think through these issues in the last four chapters. Now you'll put it all together.

GETTING AN IDEA

You can find game ideas almost anywhere, but only if you're looking for them. Creativity is an active, not a passive, process. Look everywhere; some of the most unexpected things can hide a game idea. *BioShock*, for instance, is a satire on the philosophy of Ayn Rand that asks the question, "What might happen in a libertarian utopia that allowed completely unregulated biological experimentation?," whereas *Angry Birds* is much simpler: It's just a physics-based game designed around a slingshot. There have been slingshots in games before, but none so cleverly realized.

One idea isn't enough. It's a common misconception that a brilliant game idea will make you a fortune. In fact, this occurs extremely rarely. Even if you think you have the game idea of the century, you should always look out for more. Make a note of each one and go on. If one seems especially promising, then start to expand and refine it, but don't let that prevent you from thinking about other games as well.

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Dreams of Doing

A lot of games are light entertainment, designed to while away a few minutes with a puzzle or a simple challenge. But larger, richer games begin with a dream. If you've ever thought to yourself, "I wish I could... " or "Imagine what it would be like to...," then you've taken an important step on the road to creating a video game. Computers can create almost any sort of visual and auditory experience you can imagine, even experiences that are physically impossible in the real world. The design of a game begins with the question, "What dream am I going to fulfill?"

Perhaps it's a dream of exploring a dungeon infested with monsters. Perhaps it's a dream of coaching a football team. or perhaps it's a dream of being a fashion designer. Video games allow players to have experiences that are difficult, expensive, or even impossible in the real world. Before you do anything else, you must dream the dream. Understand it. Feel it. Know who else dreams it and why.

Dreams from Other Media

Books, movies, television, and other entertainment media can be great sources of inspiration for game ideas, so long as the ideas include plenty of activity. People dream of being Spider-Man, Harry Potter, or Nancy Drew, and all these characters have video games about them. But games don't have to have licenses from famous books or TV shows just to take inspiration from them. For instance, the game *Grand Theft Auto: Vice City* borrows from the TV show *Miami Vice* (**Figure 7.1**), and the game *No One Lives Forever* is a parody of James Bond movies. Any story containing exciting action with something important at stake can form the kernel of a game. Think over the books you've read and the movies you've seen, and ask yourself whether any of the activities in them could serve as the basis for a game.

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Figure 7.1 *Grand Theft Auto: Vice City* was inspired by another medium—television.

Note

Licenses and intellectual property law are beyond the scope of this book. Generally speaking, however, you cannot use the names, artwork, audio, text, or any other material copied directly from another game or any other medium. In the United States, parody is a protected form of free speech, but your parody must be visibly distinct from the original, must actually have the function of commenting on the original, and must not be libelous or intended to inflict emotional distress. Laws in other jurisdictions vary. Be cautious: If you are in any doubt whether your content violates someone else's intellectual property rights, change it!

You can't, of course, steal other people's intellectual property. Even if the *Pirates of the Caribbean* ride at Disneyland seems like the basis for a great game, you can't make it without a license from Disney. But you can certainly make a lighthearted game about pirates—as LucasArts did with its *Monkey Island* series.

You should also look beyond the usual science fiction and fantasy genres and beyond the usual sources like novels and movies. How about poetry? Beowulf's epic battle with the monster Grendel and then his even more terrible battle with Grendel's mother in a cave at the bottom of a lake sound like the basis for a game. Alfred, Lord Tennyson's "The Charge of the Light Brigade" might make you wonder about cavalry tactics. Would a game based on cavalry warfare be interesting to anyone? It's worth thinking about.

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Game ideas can crop up in all sorts of unlikely places. The smash-hit game franchise *The Sims* was partly inspired by a nonfiction book by Christopher Alexander called *A Pattern Language* (Alexander, 1977), which is about the way people's lives are affected by the design of their houses. Just as great scientists look at even the most common things in the world—light, air, gravity—and ask how they work, great game designers are always looking at the world and wondering what parts of it they can make into a game. The trick to finding original ideas, beyond the elf-and-wizard combinations that have been done so often, is to develop a game designer's instincts, to look for the fun and challenge even in things that don't sound like games at all.

Game Ideas from Other Games

When you play a lot of games, you develop a sense of how they work and what their good and bad points are. Playing games is a valuable experience for a game designer. It gives you insight and lets you compare and contrast the features of different games.

Sometimes new game ideas are motivated by a desire to improve an existing game. We think, "If I had designed this game, I would have...." To learn from other games, you have to pay attention as you play. Don't just play them for fun; look at them seriously and think about how they work. Take notes, especially of things that you like or don't like and of features that seem to work particularly well or not well at all. How do resources flow into the game? How do they flow out? How much of your success comes from luck? How much comes from skill?

If you are inspired by an existing game, try to bring something new to it. *BioShock* and *Half-Life* weren't just shooters; they were shooters that offered something distinctly different from the ones that came before them. If pursued exclusively, imitation produces similarity and, ultimately, mediocrity. The greatest games break new ground. They're unlike anything seen on the store shelves before.

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How to Brainstorm

In the previous few sections, we looked at ways that you can generate ideas as an individual, but a great many games are designed by groups of people. *Brainstorming* is a way for several people to generate large numbers of ideas without (initially) concerning themselves about quality. You all get together in one room and think of ideas rapidly without judging their value, usually for a limited amount of time. The four principles of brainstorming are

- **Focus on quantity.** The greater the number of ideas generated, the greater the chance of producing an interesting or useful one. Don't stop to discuss an idea, simply record it and move on.
- **Withhold criticism.** Debating the value of an idea slows down the process, and if people feel that they will be criticized, they will be more reluctant to generate ideas.
- **Welcome unusual ideas.** Part of the point of brainstorming is not only to find ideas, but to find ones that you might never have considered otherwise. This is particularly important for creative endeavors like game design.
- **Combine and improve ideas.** Ideas don't have to be unique. Rather like a jam session in music, the participants can build upon each others' suggestions, adding features or combining them to make new ones.

To hold a brainstorming session, you need a room where people can sit comfortably and a person who writes down the ideas (or a way to record everyone's suggestions). Try to avoid including more than about 12 people, and appoint a leader (this might be the person taking notes) who can make sure the discussion doesn't drift off-topic.

Brainstorming can go wrong, or at least be disappointingly unproductive, in various ways. Don't let one person dominate the conversation to the point that others feel intimidated. Also, don't let anyone spend a long time explaining their idea—this might cause others to forget ideas of their own. In order to discourage side

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conversations or criticism, you might want to impose a rule like that used in government meetings, that all remarks must be addressed to the chair.

After the brainstorming session is over, then you can start debating the merits of particular ideas. There's more than one way to brainstorm; the Wikipedia article on the subject lists a number of variants.

Communicating Your Idea to Others

If your game is in a well-known genre and setting (for example, a World War II flight simulator), you can be pretty certain that a number of people will be interested in playing your game right away. But if your game is in a new setting (a futuristic city of your imagination, for example)—and especially if you are introducing a new genre—you have to be very careful and thorough in communicating your dream to others. Here are two of the first questions a publishing executive is going to ask you: "Why would people want to play this game?" and "What's going to make someone buy this game instead of another?"

> Tip
>
> Publishers will ask you what other games your game competes with. Be sure you study the market so you know what's already out there and how your game will be different and better.

So what does it mean to entertain someone? Many people think entertainment is synonymous with having fun, but even that isn't completely straightforward. People have fun in all kinds of ways. Some of those ways involve hard manual labor, such as gardening or building a new deck. Some of them involve frustration, such as solving a puzzle. Some, such as athletic competitions, even involve pain. One person's entertainment is another person's insufferable boredom. To build a game that entertains, you must know *who* it will entertain and *how*. Chapter 1, "Games and Video Games," discussed a variety of ways in which video games entertain people, and Chapter 4, "Understanding Your Player," looked at different kinds of players. Keep

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them in mind as your work takes you from dream to game.

FROM IDEA TO GAME CONCEPT

Chapter 2 described a game concept as "a general idea of how you intend to entertain someone through gameplay." That description was accurate enough for an overview, but to discuss game concepts in detail, we need a more complete explanation.

A *game concept* is a description of a game that is detailed enough that a group can begin discussing it as a potential commercial product—a piece of software that the public might want to buy. It should include, at a minimum, the following key points:

- *A high concept statement,* which is a two- or three-sentence description of what the game is about. Here's a high concept statement for a game about street football: "The game at its grittiest. No pads, no helmets, no refs, no field. Just you and the guys, a ball, and a lot of concrete."
- *The player's role(s)* in the game, if the game is representational enough to have roles. If the player will have an avatar, describe the avatar character briefly.
- *A proposed primary gameplay mode,* including camera model, interaction model, and general types of challenges the player(s) will experience in that mode.
- *The genre* of the game or, if you think it is a hybrid, which features it will incorporate from the different genres to which it belongs. If it is an entirely new kind of game, include an explanation of why its gameplay doesn't fit into any existing genre.
- *A description of the target audience* for the game and perhaps the expected rating that it will get. Chapter 4 looks at different kinds of players and the styles of play that they like.

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- *The name of the machine* on which the game will run and details of any special equipment or features the game will utilize (for example, a camera or dance mat). Chapter 5, "Understanding Your Machine," discusses the variety of game machines available.
- *A brief statement of how you expect to make money* with your game, if you intend to sell it commercially. Chapter 6, "Making Money from Your Game," describes the different places around the world where you can sell games and looks at business models for making money with games.
- *Any licensed characters or other intellectual property* that the game may be based on, such as a sports league or a movie hero.
- *The competition modes* that the game will support: single-, dual-, or multiplayer; competitive or cooperative.
- *A general summary* of how the game will progress from beginning to end, including a few ideas for levels or missions and a synopsis of the storyline, if the game has one. Do *not* spend too much time on the story. Many game developers spend too much time on the story and not enough on the gameplay.
- *A short description* of the game world.

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Tip

A good way to describe the progress of the game in a high concept document is to include a section called "The First Five Minutes of Play." This gives people a clear picture of what it will be like to begin playing your game.

You should put all these items into a high concept document. This chapter discusses how to think about these issues, except for a few that are self-explanatory or were covered in earlier chapters. You can see a sample high concept document on the companion website.

In a commercial environment, whoever funds your game (most often a publisher) wants to see several additional details: the game's potential competition, the *unique selling points* (often abbreviated USPs) that make your game stand out in the marketplace, and possible marketing strategies and related merchandising opportunities.

As you can see, a game concept is much more than an idea. It is an idea that you have thought about and begun to develop. A game concept contains enough detail that you can begin discussing how it will feel to play the game and what further design work you need to create the game.

The Player's Role

To understand your game and to explain it to others, you must know what the player will do and, in a sense, what the player will *be* in the game world—what her role is. These are the first questions you face in creating your game concept.

What Is The Player Going To Do?

It's sometimes tempting to start thinking about a game in terms of its setting or its characters. For example, "Wouldn't it be fun to play a game set in ancient Rome?" or "Wouldn't it be fun to play a game as Indiana Jones?" These are reasonable ideas, and of course many games have been made from both of them. However, you cannot make a game from a setting or character alone. The first step toward turning the idea into a game concept is to answer the question, "What is the player going to do?"

This is *the* single most important question you can ask yourself at the concept stage. You don't have to assign activities to input devices yet ("the X button kicks and the O button punches"), but you do have to know the activities that you want to offer the player—the verbs of the game. For games in some genres, the answer is simple and obvious: Drive a race car or fight in a boxing match. For games in other genres, such as role-playing games, the question may have many answers: explore, fight, cast spells, collect objects, buy and sell, talk to dragons.

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Video games allow someone to play—that is, to *act*. The player has purchased the game in order to *do* something, not just to see, hear, or read something. Interactivity is the *raison d'être* of all gaming; it is what sets gaming apart from presentational forms of entertainment such as books and movies. The correct answer to the question, "Wouldn't it be fun to play a game set in ancient Rome?" is another question: "Yes, it would. What kinds of things could a player do in ancient Rome?" The more precise you are, the better. Avoid generalities such as "the player builds a city," and think of the exact verbs to assign to the input devices: buy land, sell land, construct a road, and so on.

Design Rule **Think About Player Actions First**

Do not start designing the story, avatar, game world, artwork, or anything else until you have answered the question, "What is the player going to do?"

Defining The Role

Playing a game, especially a board game or a computer game, often involves playing a *role* of some sort. In *Monopoly*, the role is a real estate tycoon. In the *Harry Potter* games, the role is, naturally, Harry Potter. Defining the player's role in the game world is a key part of defining your game's concept. If the player's role is difficult to describe, it may be difficult for the player to grasp as well, and that may indicate conceptual problems with the game. This doesn't mean that the role always has to be simple or that the player sticks to just one role per game. In many sports games, for example, the player can be an athlete, a coach, or the general manager. In team games, the player often switches from one athlete to another as play progresses.

Shifting roles work well in a sports game because the game's audience understands them, but if your game takes place in a less familiar world with less familiar objectives, you must make the roles especially clear. If the player's role changes from time to time—especially involuntarily—the player must know why it changed and how to adapt to the new circumstances.

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Tip

The easier it is to explain the player's role, the easier it is for the publisher, the retailer, and the customer to understand it... and to decide to spend money on it.

If you explain the player's role clearly, it helps him understand what he's trying to achieve and what rules govern the game. In *America's Army*, for instance, the player takes on the role of a real-world soldier. Real soldiers can't just shoot anything that moves; they have to obey rules of engagement. By telling the player that the role is based on reality rather than fantasy, the game designer ensures that the player knows his actions will have to be more cautious than in the usual frenetic shooter game.

In defining the player's role, you face the question of how realistic you want your game to be. At the concept stage, you need not—and should not—start defining the details of the core mechanics and the presentation layer, but you should have a general idea of whether you want your game to be abstract or representational. Other considerations, such as the target audience (discussed in the section "Defining Your Target Audience," later in this chapter) may influence that decision.

Genres and Hybrids

If you're a student or an independent developer, we recommend that the first thing that you do in designing a game is define the player's role and think about the actions that will be available to that player. This allows you maximum flexibility to create any sort of game that you like. However, if you're working for a large conventional publisher, they will probably want you to make a game that fits within an existing genre. The more money the publisher spends to develop a game, the more conservative they tend to be.

Working with a well-known genre such as a shooter or a racing game gives you a shortcut through the early design process. Because conventional genres are defined in terms of their challenges, they naturally have a fairly

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standard set of actions that players will expect to find in them as well. Chapter 3, "The Major Genres," introduced them.

Note

In addition, e-books will be available for purchase from the Peachpit website that each discuss one genre in detail. They are all named *Fundamentals of* <genre name> *Design*.

Some games cross genres, combining features not typically found together. By far the most successful hybrid is the *action-adventure*, as seen in the more recent *Legend of Zelda* games. (The earlier 2D *Zelda* games were almost entirely action games.) Action-adventures are still mostly action, but they include a story and puzzles that give them some of the qualities of adventure games. Games that offer a major gameplay mode in one genre, but one or more mini-games in another, are increasingly popular. For example, *Puzzle Quest* (**Figure 7.2**) was a successful hybrid, a simple role-playing game that used the match-three gameplay of many casual games to implement combat.

Crossing genres is more work for the design and development teams and not without its risks. Rather than appealing to two groups, you might end up appealing to neither. Many players (and game reviewers) prefer particular genres and don't want to be confronted by challenges of a kind that they normally avoid. If you plan to do something unusual, be sure to playtest your idea early with people who represent your intended audience.

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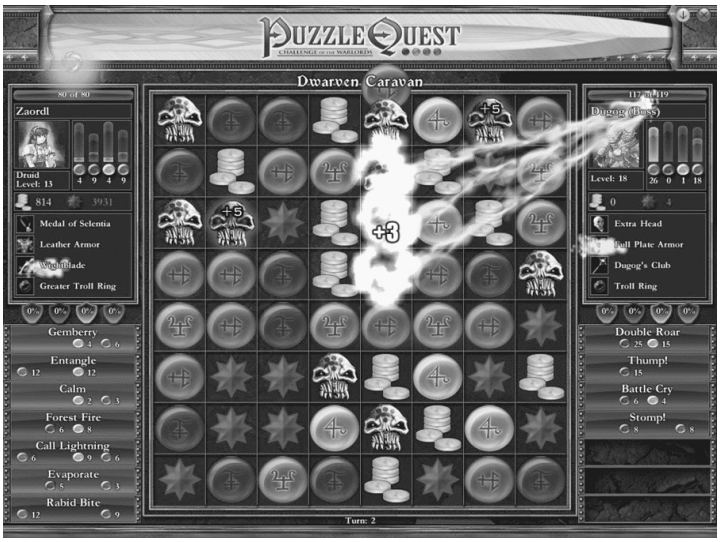

Figure 7.2 *Puzzle Quest*

However, you should not allow the standard genres to circumscribe your creativity—especially at the concept stage. If you have a wholly new, never-before-seen type of game in mind, design it as you envision it; don't try to shoehorn it into a genre to which it doesn't belong. A game needs to be true to itself, so a truly hybrid game may need to mix challenges that aren't typically presented together. But don't mix characteristics of different genres without good reason; a game should cross genres only if it genuinely needs to as part of the gameplay. A flight simulator with a logic puzzle inserted in the middle of the game just to make the game different from other flight simulators will only annoy flight sim fans.

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Note

Occasionally two people on a design team want their game to belong to different genres, and they compromise by including challenges from both. Conflicting visions are a poor reason to create a hybrid game, and the result will lack harmony.

Defining Your Target Audience

Many game designers make the mistake of thinking that all players enjoy the same things that the designer enjoys, so the designer has only to examine her own experience to know how to make a game entertaining. This is dangerous hubris. We make video games to entertain an audience. You must think about who your audience is and what *they* like. Chapter 4 and Chapter 6 address some of the issues you will encounter.

Unless you have been commissioned by a single individual, you design a game for a class of people, not for one person. At this early stage, you must think about your audience broadly, as a group of people you hope will enjoy your game. When a publisher asks, "Who will buy this game?," think carefully about the answer. What characteristics are your players likely to have in common? What things set them apart from other gamers? What challenges do they enjoy? More important, what challenges do they *not* enjoy? What interests them, bores them, frustrates them, excites them, frightens them, and offends them? Know the answers to these questions, and keep the answers close at hand as you design your game. If you don't already know your audience well, talk to some players who belong to this group and watch them play other games that are similar to the one you want to build.

> The Player-Centric Philosophy and the Target Audience
>
> As Chapter 2 explained, the player-centric philosophy of game design requires that you think about how your design decisions affect a representative player's experience of the game. This approach ensures that your decisions serve the player's interests first, especially in the later stages of development when you are often tempted to make decisions based on cost or convenience.

A game concept is not complete without a statement describing its intended audience.

Defining a target audience is not the same as player-centric design. You can apply the player-centric approach only *after* you have defined the target audience. You must begin by asking yourself the question, "Who am I trying to entertain?" Once you have that answer, you can use it to apply the player-

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centric approach to other design issues, asking yourself, "Does this feature entertain a representative player from my target audience?"

Progression Considerations

If your game will be a long one, the player will need a sense of progress through it. At this stage of game design, you must decide what will provide that sense of progress: levels, a story, or both. Will your game be so large that it should be divided into levels? Will your levels be unrelated and all available to the player at any time, or will they be organized into a sequential or branching configuration, in which completing a level makes the next one available? What types of conditions will determine when a player has completed a level? The genre that you have chosen will help you to determine your answers.

The other question is whether you want a story. Stories give games a dramatic context and goal. Some genres, such as sports and puzzle games, don't usually include stories because their context is self-explanatory. In other genres, such as role-playing and adventure games, the story is a large part of the game's entertainment.

Representational games frequently provide a story; abstract games generally don't, although *Ms. Pac-Man* was an exception in a small way. Stories about abstract characters are seldom very involving.

If you do choose to have a story in your game, you don't have to know exactly what narrative content you want to include at the concept-formation stage. All you need to know is whether you want a story and, if so, what its overall direction will be. You should be able to summarize it in a sentence or two; for example: "When Moses Oyeleye, a college student in America, inherits his father's farm in Nigeria, he finds himself in violent conflict with local bandits, the police, and Western oil companies. He has to battle to save his family and his birthright." Errors in the storyline are much easier to correct than errors in the gameplay, and gamers will forgive story errors more quickly as well. Make sure you understand your game first; then build your story into it.

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Design Rule The Story Comes Later

Do not spend a lot of time devising a story at the concept stage. This is a cardinal error frequently made by people who are more used to presentational media such as books and film. You *must* concentrate most of your efforts on the gameplay at this point.

SUMMARY

In this chapter, you learned what a game concept is and what decisions you have to make to create a high concept document. You should now understand the importance of defining the player's role. You also learned how to use game genres and how to think about choosing a target audience.

Creating a game concept is like designing the framework of a building: It gives you the general outlines but not the details. The remainder of the book is dedicated to creating those details.

DESIGN PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Create a high concept document for one of your favorite games or one that your instructor assigns.
2. Write a short paper contrasting the player's roles in a *Tomb Raider* game and a *Civilization* game.
3. Think of a hybrid game that you have played (or your instructor will assign one). Write an essay describing what worked and what didn't in combining the two different kinds of gameplay.

DESIGN PRACTICE QUESTIONS

Once you have a game idea in mind, these are the questions you must ask yourself in order to turn it into a fully fledged game concept. You don't have to be precise or detailed, but you should have a general answer for all of them.

1. Write a high concept statement: a few sentences that give a general flavor of the game. You can reference other games, movies, books, or any other media if your game contains similar characters, actions, or ideas.
2. What is the player's role? Is the player pretending to be someone or something, and if so, what? Is

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there more than one role? How does the player's role help to define the gameplay?

3. Does the game have an avatar or other key character? Describe him/her/it.
4. What is the nature of the gameplay, in general terms? What kinds of challenges will the player face? What kinds of actions will the player take to overcome them?
5. What is the player's interaction model? Omnipresent? Through an avatar? Something else? Some combination?
6. What is the game's primary camera model? How will the player view the game's world on the screen? Will there be more than one perspective?
7. Does the game fall into an existing genre? If so, which one?
8. Is the game competitive, cooperative, team-based, or single-player? If multiple players are allowed, are they using the same machine with separate controls or different machines over a network?
9. Why would anyone want to play this game? Who is the game's target audience? What characteristics distinguish them from the mass of players in general?
10. What machine or machines is the game intended to run on? Can it make use of, or will it require, any particular hardware such as dance mats or a camera?
11. What is the game's setting? Where does it take place?
12. Will the game be broken into levels? What might be the victory condition for a typical level?
13. Does the game have a narrative or story as it goes along? Summarize the plot in a sentence or two.

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